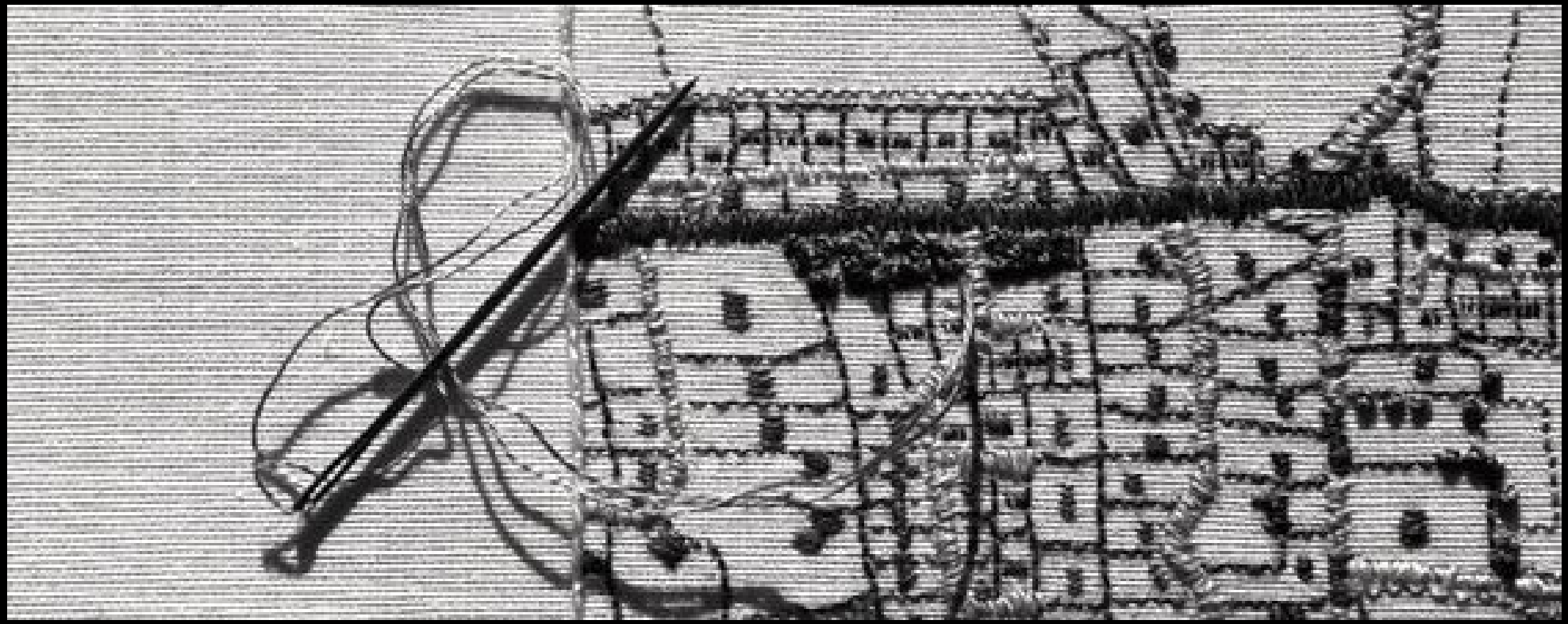
THE CONTINUING THREADLINE

embroidered human inheritance holding together in the Asia Pacific

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK FOR THE KEYNOTE EXHIBITION OF *SUI DHAGA* 2026



A COLLABORATIVE SHOWCASE BY

ARTHSHILA DELHI

CRAFTS COUNCIL OF INDIA

DELHI CRAFTS COUNCIL

AHAD ANHAD

ASIA PACIFIC CRAFT ALLIANCE

SUPPORTED BY

GOOD EARTH Heritage Foundation

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As it may be for water to flow, so it is for the continuous, self-evolving line of thread to hold things together, as a witness of time.

Emboldened by the technology of the needle, it runs through the familiar fabric of the everyday. It rests, repairs, and repeats itself across a united turf, developing into vocabularies of design; eroding binaries of craft and art, of the traditional and the contemporary, and serving as a biography rooted in diverse cartographies of collective making with measure and memory.



THE CONTINUING THREADLINE—Keynote Exhibition of *Sui Dhaga* 2026 is being conceived to inspire wonder and awe for works of intense craftsmanship in evidence, and to build empathy for their making rituals within the lives and places where they're made. Positioning time-honoured embroidery practices as human inheritance and as a document of cultural history, and stitched together with 'continuity & innovation' as its curatorial spine—this exhibition will invoke audiences to plunge the depths of design, representing the aesthetic sensibility of disparate civilisations, regions, communities, and the self situated within them.

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holding together
with needle and thread

sui dhaga
2026

THE CONTINUING THREADLINE

Time-stitched embroideries from the Asia Pacific

—read as ornament, craft, inheritance, identity, social text, territory and testimony, through a spatially layered, porous architecture.

If the stitch has a life as old as humankind and as long as its common destiny, then let's follow it back in time, to the future—for in its practice, embroidery pickles repositories of self-reckoning, generation loss, belonging and reclamation.

Embroidery is as much the pulse of history as the rivers we know or
the trees that will outlive us—patient, rhythmic, and resilient.
Each stitch marks presence, each knot holds memory.
Across the Asia-Pacific, people have embroidered their worlds into being
—with devotion, with beauty, through the wrestles of survival.



Stage set of *Contempt* (2018) cited as a prospective design direction for 'porous architecture' within gallery spaces.







spatially layered, porous architecture







Contempt (2018) stage set lit externally with projections, and internally with overhead spotlights.

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

Galleries will be subdivided into porous corridors, enclosing smaller, inner spaces responding to the narrative hierarchy, to serve the following purposes:

- to shift the familiar or notional sense of space including assumptions of entry & exit points, and to enable discovery through choreographed navigation guided by the space itself.
- to reveal the contents of the space in stages, as against being visually accessible all at once, upon entry.
- to coax an up-close and intimate viewing as necessitated by the nature of the subject, requiring investment in minutiae— not just of the embroidered works on display but indeed of the emotional register of the unfolding stories.



Further citation for prospective design directions in evolving a 'porous architecture': *Rooh-ji-Rehan* —sound installation from nomadic desert landscapes for Living Lightly (Ahmedabad 2017, Delhi 2016)

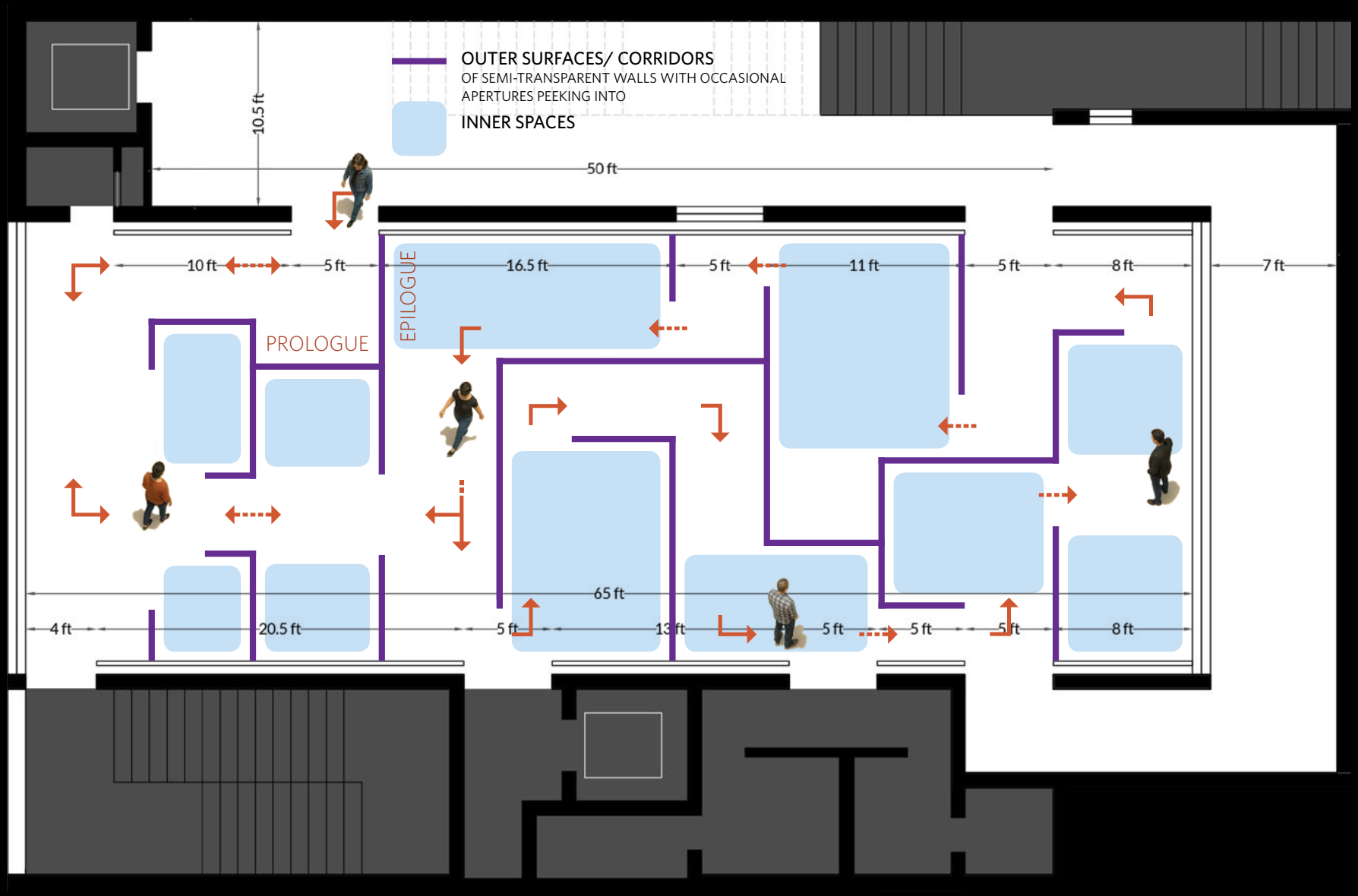






SCALED MOCK-LAYOUT OF GALLERY 01 AT ARTHSHILA **DELHI**

—to illustrate the intended choreography of Outer Surfaces & Corridors enclosing Inner Spaces.
The spatial density is indicative, and will vary across galleries in response to exhibits, installations and programmed activities within the gallery spaces.



CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

OUTER SURFACES celebrating technique, pattern and the brilliance of formal imaginaries in virtuous masterpieces with visual worlds of motif and meaning handed down through generations; and bringing into focus, the adaptive muscle of these hand-crafting traditions.

EXHIBIT EXAMPLES

North and Central Asia sub-region
Uzbek suzani: floral designs of Bukhara, simplified patterns of Samarkand, and the bright ornaments of Surkhandarya—embroidered dowry legacies handed down from mothers to daughters across generations to this day.



CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

EXHIBIT EXAMPLES FOR OUTER SURFACES

The Malay Archipelago and Maritime Southeast Asia
Songket, sulam, and beaded textiles of Sumatra, Sarawak, and the Philippines —metallic threads shimmering like currents, speaking of trade, encounter, and cultural syncretism.



Sulam embroidery, East Sumatra, Indonesia



Keringkam (gold thread) embroidery, Sarawak, Malaysia

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

EXHIBIT EXAMPLES FOR OUTER SURFACES

South Asia
Phulkari, Kantha, Zardozi, Rabari, and Kashmiri crewel work—embroidery as both ornament and narrative; rural women's archive of emotion and continuity.

Phulkari embroidery, Punjab

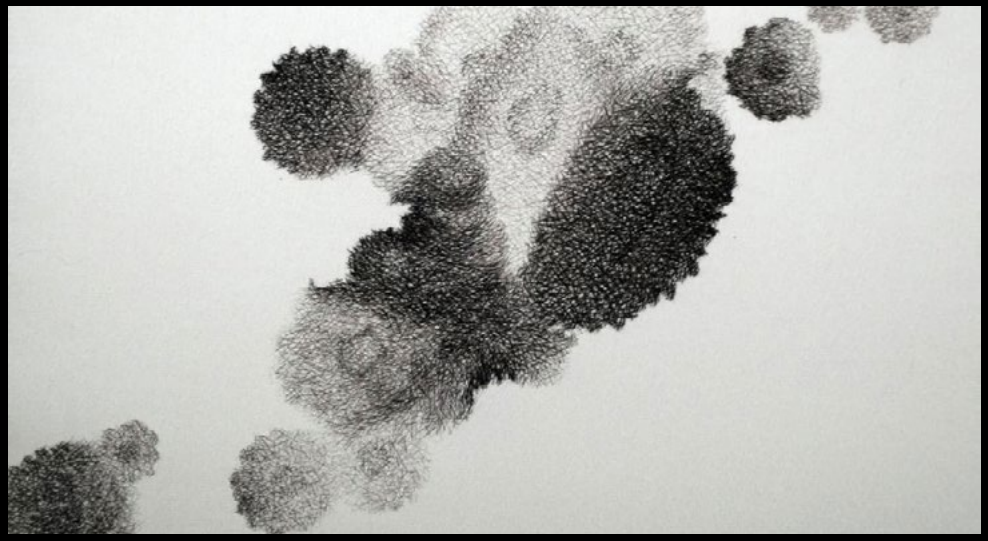




CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

EXHIBIT EXAMPLES FOR OUTER SURFACES

East Asia
Chinese silk embroidery, Japanese sashiko, Korean bojagi
—meditations on repair, perfection and philosophy through thread.



Embroideries by Liang Xuefang, Jiangsu province art and craft master





CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

INNER SPACES: Quieter chanting spaces, contextually scenographed with local stories and cartographies of change will relate to the communities behind the works seen on the Outer Surfaces.

Physical readings of testimonies from the ground will be programmed into the imagination of Inner Spaces for discovery by audience members while on their walk through the galleries. In the absence of the reader, a facsimile of the story will take her place, inviting the audience to sit, and read by themselves.



Digital simulations of scenographic intent for Inner Spaces.



CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

PROSPECTIVE THEMES FOR INNER SPACES

Embroidery as remembrance—of ancestors, migration and loss and recovery.

Kantha quilts from Bengal made from worn saris, layered with personal histories.

Miao and Hmong textiles carrying mythical motifs as mnemonic devices.

A contemporary installation from Kashmir on the disappeared, re-imagining crewel work as testimony.





Digital simulations of scenographic intent for Inner Spaces.

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

PROSPECTIVE THEMES FOR INNER SPACES

Embroidery as remembrance





Shivaranjan V's narrative embroideries in felt, of remembered ancestral tales from pastoral communities of the Deccan.
Courtesy: Centre for Pastoralism, New Delhi

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

THEMATICS FOR INNER SPACES

Embroidery as collective ritual

The embroidered narratives on the sacred Kacholi are rich with representations of the shepherd's life in the Deccan and symbolisms of folklore and communal identity within broader themes of economy, tradition, and trade.











Images courtesy
Gauri Subbaramu, Bangalore

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

PROSPECTIVE THEMES FOR INNER SPACES

Embroidery as collective ritual







Gauri Subbaramu's classroom installation (at Srishti Manipal Institute of Art, Design & Technology, Bangalore) on the material culture of the 'Kacholi' worn by Dhangars during the Mayakka devi jatre at the Mayakka temple in Chinchali village, Raybag taluk, Belagavi district, Karnataka.

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

PROSPECTIVE THEMES FOR INNER SPACES

Embroidery as shared labour and collective making

Photographic and video documentation of Lao and Thai women embroidering temple banners together.

Pacific Island tivaevae making circles—embroidery as conversation and care.

A communal space for demonstration & initiation where the local community in the neighborhood of the exhibition site as well as audience members are invited to experience the practice with participating artisans.





Images courtesy *Rafooghar*—a safe, creative space deploying embroidery for repair, restoration and rejuvenation.

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

PROSPECTIVE THEMES FOR INNER SPACES

Embroidery as a shared labour, collective making

Created into a canopy, 992 women from Maldhari communities of Kutch contributed a patch of embroidery each as their signature of complicity in asking 'to be seen' by the audience of administrators and citizens from disparate worlds.







Living Lightly (2017)

CONCEPTUAL APPROACH & ITS SPATIAL PROOF

PROSPECTIVE THEMES FOR INNER SPACES

Embroidery as defiance

(both images in the right column) Burmese Chin women's textiles, coded with hidden political messages.

(bottom) Chilean arpilleras in dialogue with Asian examples—stitching under regimes of censorship (and displacement).

Contemporary works addressing gender, ecology, and protest through textile intervention.







1 OF 3 ARCHITECTURAL CHOREOGRAPHY FOR NAVIGATION

WITH OUTER SURFACES AND INNER SPACES DISCUSSED THUS FAR

From awe-inspiring virtuosity, the exhibition's porous architecture enables intermittent peeks into intimate histories of disruption in *The Continuing Threadline*—from war, migration, the market or modernisation.

2 OF 3 INTERPRETATIVE LAYERS

Conventional wall text and labels will be minimised in favour of embroidered text as artistic signature, and audio testimonies in makers' voices.

Archival images, maps, and sketches will highlight regional distinctions.

Digital stations will allow visitors to trace the journey of motifs such as the lotus or the tree-of-life traveling across cultures and centuries through embroidery.

MAPS OF INCOMPLETION

—a conceptual sub-frame for articulating territorial stories of makers.

A mapping of incompletion embraces absence, ambiguity, and partial knowledge as part of the mapping process.

It resists the idea of total overview. It values what's missing: the blank spaces, silences, erasures, or uncharted zones—as the keeper of insights.

It is the cartography of becoming—a recognition that both the world and our understanding of it are in flux.

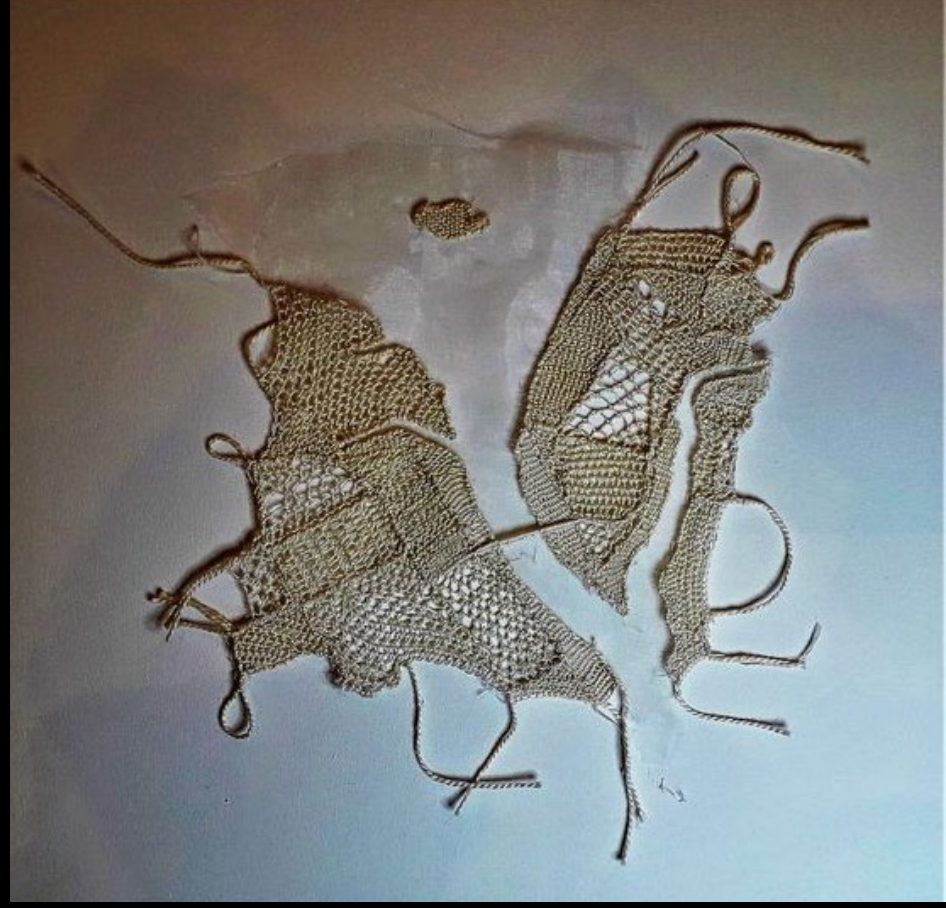


STRATEGY SUMMATION

2 OF 3 INTERPRETATIVE LAYERS

MAPS OF INCOMPLETION

Textual imaginaries of continuity, confinement and fracture inspiring commissioned maps as collaborations between traditional embroiderers and writers & dramaturgs.



A free bird leaps
on the back of the wind
and floats downstream
till the current ends
and dips his wing
in the orange sun rays
and dares to claim the sky.

But a bird that stalks
down his narrow cage
can seldom see through
his bars of rage
his wings are clipped and
his feet are tied
so he opens his throat to sing.

The caged bird sings
with a fearful trill
of things unknown
but longed for still
and his tune is heard
on the distant hill
for the caged bird
sings of freedom.

The free bird thinks of another breeze
and the trade winds soft through the sighing trees
and the fat worms waiting on a dawn bright lawn
and he names the sky his own.

— *Caged Bird* by Maya Angelou

STRATEGY SUMMATION

2 OF 3 INTERPRETATIVE LAYERS

MAPS OF INCOMPLETION

Collaborative textual maps.

The tame bird was in a cage, the free bird in the forest.
They met when the time came, it was a decree of fate.

The free bird cries, "O my love, let us fly to the wood."
The cage bird whispers, "Come hither, let us both live in the cage."

Says the free bird, "Among bars, where is there room to spread one's wings?"
"Alas," cries the caged bird, "I should not know where to sit perched in the sky."

The free bird cries, "My darling, sing the songs of the woodlands."
The cage bird sings, "Sit by my side, I'll teach you the speech of the learned."

The forest bird cries, "No, ah no! songs can never be taught."
The cage bird says, "Alas for me, I know not the songs of the woodlands."

Their love is intense with longing, but they never can fly wing to wing.
Through the bars of the cage they look, wishing in vain to know each other.
They flutter their wings in yearning, and sing, "Come closer, my love!"

—Tagore



STRATEGY SUMMATION

2 OF 3 INTERPRETATIVE LAYERS

MAPS OF INCOMPLETION



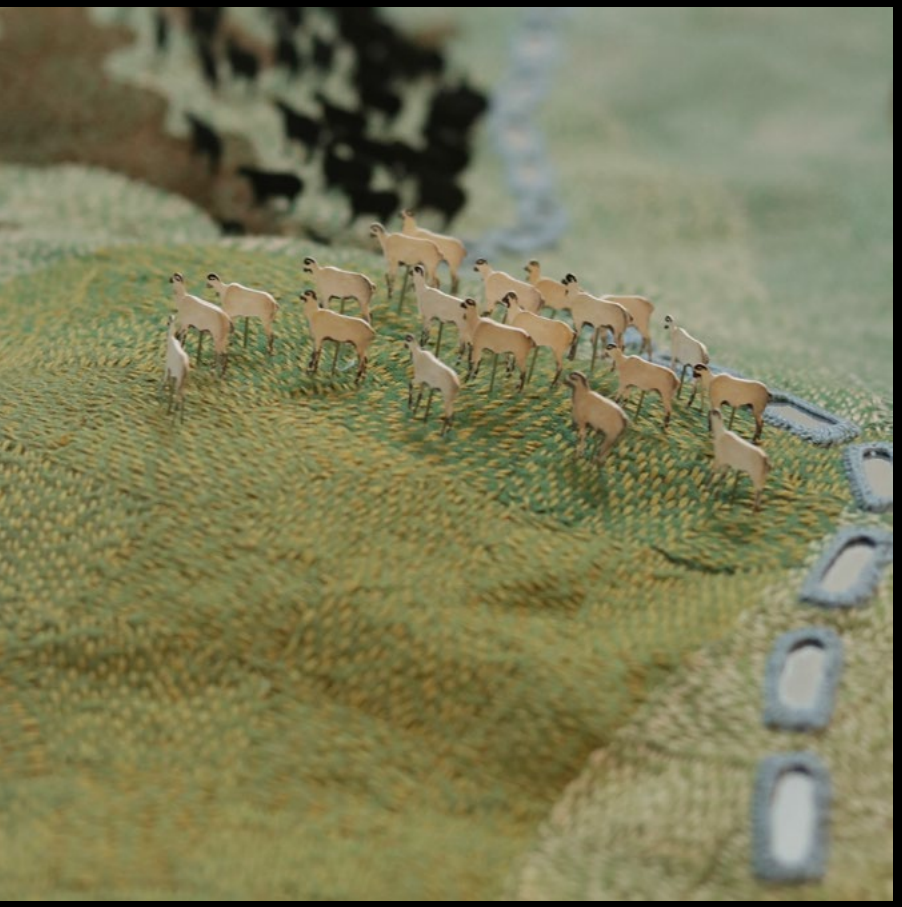


Hand-embroidered map of seasonal pastoral movement across the Deccan guided by the *Nakshatras*, and disrupted by climate change, inter-state forest policies among others.
Made by MORI DESIGN, Ahmedabad. Courtesy: Centre for Pastoralism, New Delhi

STRATEGY SUMMATION

2 OF 3 INTERPRETATIVE LAYERS

MAPS OF INCOMPLETION





Miniature pastoral animals by The Paper Ark. Courtesy: Centre for Pastoralism, New Delhi

SUMMATION OF STRATEGIES

3 OF 3 CONTEMPORARY INTERVENTIONS/ INSTALLATIONS

Commissioned works that respond to heritage with urgency.

Collaborations between traditional embroiderers and contemporary artists that reinterpret stitch as light, sound, or movement/ result in monumental aggregations of stitches in human history.

SUMMATION OF SPATIAL HIERARCHY

Thresholds and in-between spaces such as a stairs and stair-wells; pre-gallery spaces such as the lobby and the area outside auditorium: Evidence of Transitions in the Evolution of Embroidery (annexure), to premise the rest of the exhibtion formalised within the galleries.

Outer surfaces: Virtuosity & Innovation; Directories of Regional Aesthetics

Inner Spaces: Memory, Community, Resistance, Residue

Exit Corridor/ open terrace/ courtyard: Repair & Reclamation through Collaborative Reinterpretations



Digital simulations of scenographic intent.

SUMMATION OF STRATEGIES

3 OF 3 CONTEMPORARY INTERVENTIONS/ INSTALLATIONS





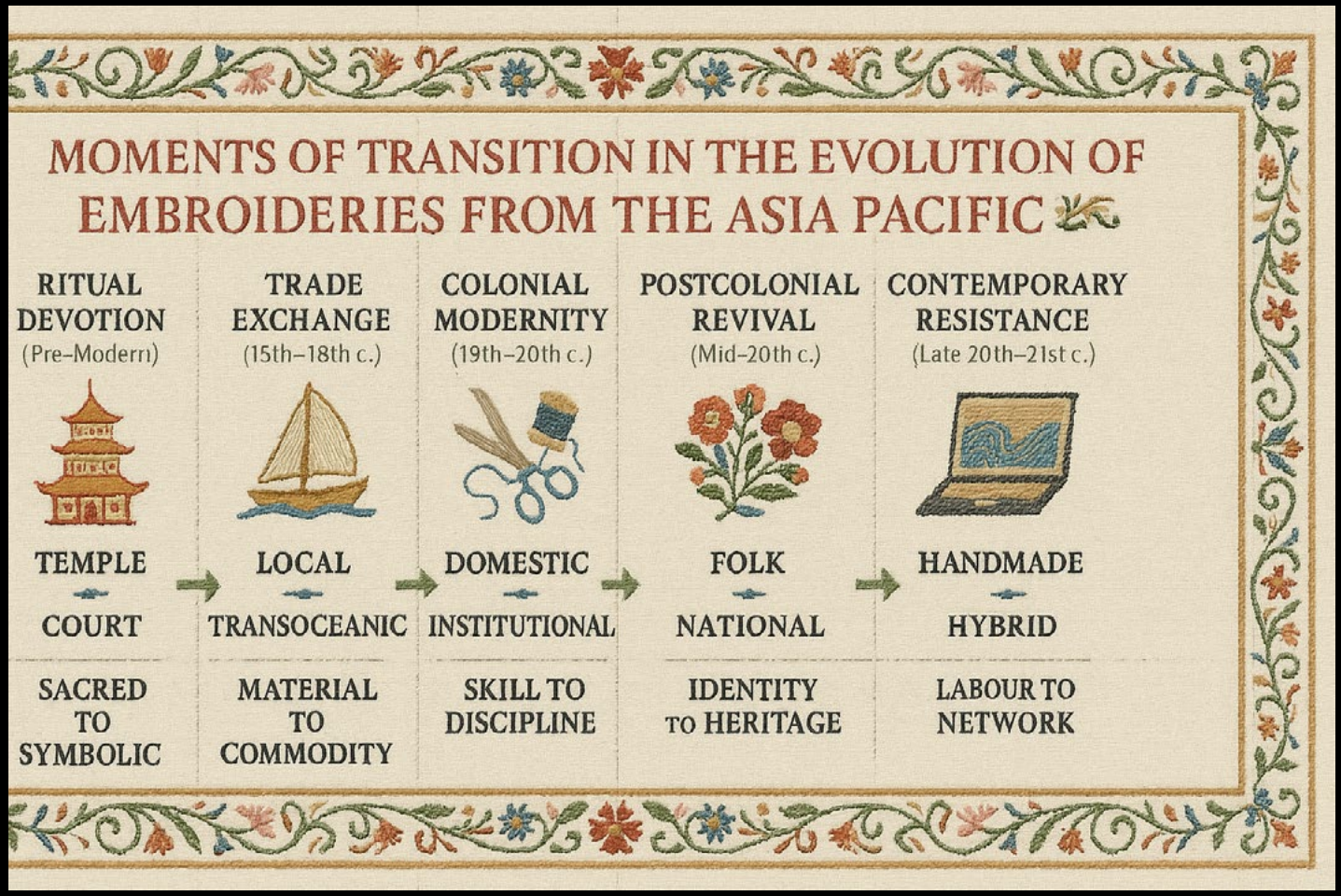
Hand embroidered river map. Bridget Steel-Jessop, UK.

ANNEXURE

TRANSITIONS IN THE EVOLUTION OF EMBROIDERY FROM THE ASIA PACIFIC

THE CONTINUING THREADLINE—*Sui Dhaga*'s Keynote Exhibition departs from this edifice of origin stories

- to build empathy and a deeper human context for the diversity of masterful embroideries on display
- to enable appreciation of innovative responses coded within traditions of craftsmanship
- to connect the practice of embroidery to the history of our world
- to invoke our shared sense of value to uphold, to protect and to hand down.



To embroider is to hold time in your hands.
These threads carry currents of oceans and empires,
of birth and mourning, of a child's laughter and a woman's silence.
The Continuing Threadline invites you to listen
—to embroidery as witness.